

JACOB (YUTAO) HE

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EDUCATION

Hong Kong Baptist University (HKBU) PhD in Sociology, Supervisor: Roger Patulny, Co-Supervisor: Dahye Kim	HKSAR 2025 – Present
The University of Hong Kong (HKU) Master of International and Public Affairs (<i>GPA: 3.84/4.30, 1st class honor with distinction</i>) Overseas Study, Peking University (PKU)	HKSAR 2023 – 2024 Beijing, China
The University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA) Bachelor of Arts in Philosophy (<i>GPA: 3.86/4.00</i>) Dean's Honors List Fall 2022	Los Angeles, U.S. 2021 – 2023
The University of California, Santa Barbara (UCSB) <i>Transferred to UCLA (GPA: 3.88/4.00, UCSB Honors Program)</i> Philosophy Major, Concentration: Ethics and Public Policy Dean's Honors List Winter 2020, Spring 2020, Fall 2020, Winter 2021, Spring 2021	Santa Barbara, U.S. 2019 – 2021

RESEARCH INTERESTS

I am a first year PhD student in Sociology focusing on social artificial intelligence (SAI), emotional well-being, and aging. My research examines how AI-mediated interactions influence loneliness, social connectedness, and perceptions of care among older adults, with attention to ethical and cultural contexts. I am also interested in human-robot interaction, technology acceptance in later life, and the broader social implications of AI in caregiving.

Keywords: Loneliness, AI Intimacy, Ethical AI & Personal Dignity, Qualitative Method, and Ageing.

WORKING PAPER

“I would not be a burden on a robot.” A scoping review of older adults' ‘lonely-emotional complexes’ when using Social AI (SAI), *Lead author of the paper, co-authored with Roger Patulny and Dahye Kim.*

Rapid global population aging has intensified what is increasingly described as a loneliness crisis. Insufficient social support among many older adults, compounded by caregiver shortages, has prompted growing interest in ‘Social’ AI (SAI) as a technological response. Yet it remains unclear whether using SAI to manage loneliness also provokes a broader range of emotions and how these shape its effectiveness.

This scoping review addresses three questions: Do different types of loneliness interact differently with SAI use? What emotions beyond loneliness emerge during initial engagement? What emotions complicate longer-term use? We reviewed 16 studies and identified eight themes: (1) negative emotions and scepticism; (2) positive emotions and SAI as a safe haven; (3) emotional work; (4) facilitation of social interaction; (5) personalization; (6) demographic and structural influences; (7) under- and over-attachment; and (8) concerns over privacy and control.

This review contributes in three ways. First, it highlights how social, emotional, and existential loneliness remain under-theorized in SAI research. Second, it shows that emotions such as comfort, attachment, ambivalence, and unease are shaped by users' social contexts and influence engagement. Third, it demonstrates that managing loneliness through SAI is itself emotionally complex, potentially fostering connection while deepening existential and collective loneliness. These findings offer nuanced implications for practitioners and policymakers.

Understanding Men's ‘Lonely emotion complexes’ – a scoping review, *co-authored with Roger Patulny, Jiashan Han, Samuel Cabbuag, and John Ratcliffe*

Loneliness is increasingly recognised as a major public health and social concern, yet relatively little is known about how it is experienced, interpreted and managed by men negotiating contemporary masculinities. This paper presents a thematic synthesis of qualitative studies examining men's lived experiences of loneliness, addressing how masculinities shape men's recognition and understanding of loneliness, the emotions accompanying loneliness, the social contexts in which loneliness is experienced, and the strategies men use to manage it. In total, eight themes were discovered.

We conclude that men's loneliness is a dynamic emotional and relational process shaped by competing masculinities, social contexts and ‘lonely-emotion complexes’. Addressing it requires moving beyond individual pathology to create socially and emotionally safe environments that support diverse masculinities, belonging and meaningful connection.

Presentations

2026: International Doctoral Symposium 2026, Global Perspectives on Social Problems, Policy, and Practice

2025: Hong Kong Sociological Association (HKSA) 26th Annual Conference

Invited Paritipation

2026: Project Finale Symposium Digital Ethics and Responsibilities From Digital Ethics to Resilience: Navigating Responsibility and AI Literacy in Higher Education and Beyond

Round Table Discussion: AI Literacy as a Pathway to Student Agency

SUMMER SCHOOL ACTIVITIES

AI Anthropology Workshop

Sun Yat-sen University, Shenzhen, 2026

QualiTaTi Summer School: Qualitative Research in the AI Era

Virtual, 2026

TEACHING AND RELATED EXPERIENCES

Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR

2025 – 2026

Teaching Assistant for SOCI 2005 Qualitative Methods of Social Research, Roger Patulny

Teaching Assistant for SOCI 1005 Invitation to Sociology, Gregory Fayard

Teaching Assistant for SOCI 1005 Invitation to Sociology, Roger Patulny

Teaching Assistant for SOCI 3035 Sex, Gender and Society, Day Wong

The University of California, Santa Barbara, US

Teaching & Research Assistant to Prof. Ralph Gallucci

2019 – 2020

NON-ACADEMIC EXPERIENCE

UCLA/UCSB CSSA (Chinese Students and Scholars Association) Soccer Team Los Angeles/Santa Barbara, U.S.
Team Captain Sept. 2019 – May 2023

- Organized soccer tryouts, practice, and scrimmages with neighboring schools, including USC, UCI and UCSB
- Led UCLA CSSA team to reach the final of the IM League, received Best Goal Award in 2023 Winter Season
- Negotiated with businesses and secured sponsorship funding for the soccer team for four years

Real Impact Missions, Inc. (RIM)

Dallas, U.S.

Long-term Volunteer & Coordinator — Program Link: <https://www.realimpact.com/> Mar. 2017 – Apr. 2019

- Participated in mission trips to the Dominican Republic in 2017, Jamaica in 2018, and Panama in 2019
- Assisted in the construction of school buildings, playgrounds, and houses for local schools and residents; organized and performed a drama about Jesus's crucifixion and resurrection at local schools, parks, and prisons
- Operated RIM's social media accounts (Instagram and Facebook), shooting photos and producing posters

Mango TV

Changsha, China

Film & Television Planning Assistant

Jun. – Sept. 2023

- Collaborated with a Mango supervisor and completed a paper, *Research on the Social Emotional Trends in TV Series and Films in the Post - Pandemic Era*, exploring the changes of social emotions affected by the pandemic and the resulting economic influence
- Created content and designed promotional poster and videos for a stage drama, *180 Days Paternity Plan*

SCHOOL ACTIVITIES

Three-Minute Presentation Finalist, *awarded HKD 1,500*

HKBU, 2026

MC activities

HKBU, 2026

AESC, HK Green Energy Week Forum

International Doctoral Symposium 2026, Global Perspectives on Social Problems, Policy, and Practice

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Hobbies & Interests: Hiking, Soccer, Skiing

Computer Skills: Adobe Family (Photoshop, Illustrator, Premiere), Microsoft Office, Web Design

Language Skills: Mandarin Chinese (Native), English (Fluent), Spanish (Basic), Cantonese (Basic)

REFERENCES

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